The Wounded Do Not Cry

By Lavonne Mueller

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

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VOICE OVER: Now hear this! Now hear this! The William N. Pendleton U.s. Merchant Marine Ship: All troops to your debarkation areas! All troops to your debarkation areas!

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: Two hours after Lieut. Frances Slanger and other Army nurses waded ashore in Normandy on D-plus-four, they were at work.
ACTRESS 2: They slept on the ground, wore the same clothes four days running. In five weeks of rugged going they helped handle 3,000 casualties.
ACTRESS 1: "We have learned a great deal about our American soldier and the stuff he is made of. The wounded do not cry. Their buddies come first. The patience and determination they show, the courage and fortitude they have is sometimes awesome to behold."
ACTRESS 2: Inspired by the life of Frances Slanger, forgotten heroine of the Normandy invasion:
TOGETHER: The Wounded Do Not Cry by Lavonne Mueller

IRENE: Frances ... Frances ... this way. The Forty-Fifth they said is this way.

FRANCES: My legs are itchy from the salt water.

IRENE: Thank heavens my lipstick is wrapped in plastic.

FRANCES: *[Pause. Looks back.]* Where is everybody?

IRENE: Keep paddling!

FRANCES: Eisenhower said we're embarking on the Great Crusade, Irene.

IRENE: Did he mention that sea water's bad for the hair?

FRANCES: He just said: Send the nurses to Normandy.

IRENE: Be careful, .. the Germans sometimes bulldoze furrows in the water. The depth can drop from chest-high to ten feet.

FRANCES: Ok ... Ok.

IRENE: Don't touch that thing! It's a mine lashed to the top of a pole. My boyfriend told me about these.

FRANCES: Why didn't we learn to dog paddle at Fort Devins?

IRENE: We were too busy learning how to dodge bullets.

FRANCES: I've got Keats under my helmet.

IRENE: It'll take more than any Keats to stop bullets. *[They struggle in the water.]*

FRANCES: There's ... dead bodies floating by me.

IRENE: Frances, there will be hundreds more to come.

FRANCES: I'm going to help them.

IRENE: Don't touch that boot! Let it go by.

FRANCES: But, Irene ... there's part of a leg still in it.

IRENE: We're only a few yards from the beach. Frances ... Frances ... [*Irene grabs Frances and Frances' head comes up out of the water as France spits out water.]*

FRANCES: I'm ok. Just gulped a little water.

IRENE: When we hit the beach, we hook up with the men.

FRANCES: Where are the rest of us nurses?

IRENE: Waiting for two slowpokes.

FRANCES: I can't see the beach.

IRENE: It's there. Murky looking from the heat. Now let's go. Double time! *[They struggle in the water and then finally fall flat on the beach gasping.]* And I dreamed of wearing one of those cute starched white nurse's hats.

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FRANCES: My hair's too frizzy to wear under any starched hat.

IRENE: Mine isn't. *[Pause.]* See anybody?

FRANCES: Not yet. *[Pause.]* I look good in a helmet. Makes my eyes bigger. [*Irene takes off her helmet and we see her hair is in large metal rollers.]* You .. .look like ... a Picasso.

IRENE: Is that a good thing?

FRANCES: "Nothing's good or bad but thinking makes it so."

IRENE: Do you have to sound like a poet during this invasion? [*Frances screams.]*

IRENE: What's wrong?

FRANCES: *[Happily.]* You called me a poet.

IRENE: It's enough to be a nurse. *[We hear artillery shells. Irene puts her helmet on as they both duck down.]* Now that's something to scream about. Why did I think this job would be glamorous?

FRANCES: Irene, whoever said war was glamorous?

IRENE: For one, it's that war poet you're always reading. What's his name .... Owen?

FRANCES: I'm not doing this because of him. I'm here to stop the Nazis.

IRENE: Before we do that, I'd like to take down my curlers. *[They cautiously look up.]*

FRANCES: Where is everybody?

IRENE: Guess we drifted off to the north.

FRANCES: Way down there ... see all that ... driftwood?

IRENE: Don't look, Frances.

FRANCES: Are those ... ?

IRENE: We've got to find the hospital.

FRANCES: Oh, god, what's happening here?

IRENE: We're at the front, Frances.

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FRANCES: Are the other nurses dead, too?

IRENE: They're probably hooked up with the men. *[Light up on a doctor who is a captain.]*

SCENE BREAK (Irene assumes the role of DOCTOR in this scene)

DOCTOR: Girls. Over here! *[They walk to the hospital area.]*

FRANCES: Where are the other nurses?

DOCTOR: Helping bring in the wounded. Push those two footlockers together. [*Irene and Frances push the two footlockers together.]*

FRANCES: *[To Doctor]* For your instruments?

DOCTOR: For my patients. I'll soon be up to my neck in surgery.

FRANCES: This is an operating table?

DOCTOR: Where the hell are you from, little girl?

FRANCES: Boston.

DOCTOR: You want Boston General hospital here? Greenhorns. Why me!

FRANCES: We're both fully qualified graduates of ...

DOCTOR: Yah ... yah. Look for flashlights. Supply dumped them somewhere around here.

FRANCES: Flashlights?

DOCTOR: Need light to operate. Even in Boston, they got to have light. We're expecting 10,000 dead. The dead we don't worry about. Now the hundreds of wounded ...

FRANCES: Hundreds?

DOCTOR: Mangled hundreds. Batteries! Little girls, if there are flashlights, can batteries be far behind? When you get time, hang some lanterns, too. And put up the mosquito netting. I want all the glass syringes boiled. And ladies ..

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.if you need the latrine, there's a slit-trench on the left side of our tent. A private will be stationed out there to issue you three squares of toilet paper per visit. *[Sound of trucks is heard.]*

SCENE BREAK

IRENE: *[Fanning herself with a large bandage.]* The air's stifling in this tent. *[Pause.]* Getting any sleep?

FRANCES: I was in surgery all night. *[Sound of distant artillery.]*

IRENE: *[About artillery:]* That bother you?

FRANCES: I pretend it's the elevated trains from South Port Station near my house in Boston.

IRENE: The one thing that really gets to me ...

FRANCES: ... when the German planes fly over?

IRENE: Trying to take a bath in a helmet full of rainwater, twigs and worms.

FRANCES: I dream about soap.

IRENE: Oh, I finally got some. From one of the medics who got a package from home. He wanted two bucks for it, but I'm so broke, Frances, did you always want to be a nurse?

FRANCES: Sure. You?

IRENE: In third grade a little boy smashed his finger on the jungle bars. I wrapped my hankie around his pinkie. He looked at me with adoring eyes. I figured ... good way to get a guy's attention. And here I am. What got you going?

FRANCES: A pear. My dad's a fruit peddler in South Boston.

IRENE: No kidding.

FRANCES: I helped him since I was seven. *[Pause.]* We always took such pride

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stacking the fruit ... polishing apples to put their cheeks next to steps of golden oranges weaving lace of purple and green grapes along the side. Then a big juicy pear on top. But there were kids who didn't like us, and they'd knock over our cart. Once ... the pear rolled away .. .it's flesh all torn. *[She reaches for a stone on the beach as if it were the pear.]* I tried pushing all the pulp back together. *[She squeezes the stone.]* I wanted to make it better ... make it whole again. *[She squeezes the stone harder.]* I wanted it ... perfect .. .like it was.

IRENE: *[Tries to get Frances to release her hold on the stone.]* Good lord, Frances, that's a sharp stone. Come on, let go.

FRANCES: Fruit has such a short life .... and crooks had to smash it .... bigots had to kill it.

IRENE: Drop it ... Frances, it's like a knife ... your hand's starting to bleed.

SCENE BREAK

SHOUTS OF: Nurse! Nurse! Nurse! *[Irene exits. A pause as Frances drops the stone on the ground and wipes her blood stained hands on the side of her uniform and then goes to the ward of the wounded. She stands in the middle of the stage surrounded by agonizing shouts of Nurse! Nurse!* [*Frances goes to the cot of one wounded soldier. She takes his temperature.]*

FRANCES: Good. You're down to 101 today. *[She goes to another cot carrying a towel over her arm.]* I'm going to give you a new wonder drug-Pencillin. You'll be up and around in no time. What? Yes. Yes. I've taken care of your friends ... they're fine. No, I didn't let them see the medicine I'm giving you. That's right, we don't want to alarm them. See, I've hidden the syringe under my towel. *[She now gives him a shot.] [She goes to another cot with a soldier with a head bandage.]* Your bandage needs tightening. Here, I'll just

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pull this closer. Tonight, I'll come back and read your wife's letter to you. *[She goes to another cot.]* You must eat. I know C-rations aren't too delicious. But you must eat. Let me put some mash potatoes on your tongue. Take a little ... please ... just a little. Good ... good. That's it. If you taste something sweet you're probably biting into a worm. Not to worry. The worm's cooked long enough to be sterilized. *[Chuckles.] [She looks out over all the cots.]* I know ... I know ... all of you want banana cream pie. Well I'd give anything to see a fat chicken on a platter for Shabbat dinner, myself. *[She turns to the next patient in the next cot as light goes up on Irene.]*

IRENE: Frances ... that's a German soldier. They found him on the beach.

FRANCES: Irene, we need more cotton.

IRENE: Frances, I can take care of him for you.

FRANCES: We're winning the war. I can afford a dose of compassion. *[To the German soldier:]* I'm just pouring sulfanilamide powder on your wounds. It will help fight the infection. *[Pause.]* What? *[She puts her ear down next to his lips.]* Yes. Juden. I'm 2nd Lt. Freidel Yachet Schlanger, United States Army Nurse Corps. *[She powders his wounds. Frances then turns to another soldier as Irene calls to her:]*

IRENE: Frances, where did you get that box of surgical gloves and extra bed pans?

FRANCES: *[As she is bandaging a patient:]* Doc sent me up the road to the Supply Hut.

IRENE: That's dangerous. The road's plastered with mines.

FRANCES: Doc just said: Look for chickens. If they're clucking and alive, the area is probably safe from mines.

SCENE BREAK

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FRANCES: Dear Mama and Papa, I know you are unhappy about me being so far away. But didn't you both leave Poland and travel to America? *[Pause.]* So you've heard about the Invasion. And they rang the church bells at 3 a.m. in Boston. I'm happy to know my Mama and Papa knelt on our front porch at 3 a.m. in their nightclothes and prayed for us here. *[Pause.]* I wash soldiers. Give morphine shots. Bandage wounds. Put kidney basins under bleeding chins. *[Pause.]* They brought in a 20-year-old boy, a bullet in both arms. He wanted me to patch him up in a hurry so he could grab his gun and go back into battle. I tried to calm him ... put cold cloths on his forehead ... rubbed his back ... even as the doctor stood behind him ready to amputate both his arms.

SCENE BREAK (Irene assumes the role of Lt. Stein in this scene)

VOICES OF SOLDIERS Nurse! Nurse! Nurse! [*Frances goes to the soldiers.]*

FRANCES: *[Bending over a soldier on a cot.]* A splintered bone has cut an artery, lieutenant.

LT STEIN: Am I.going to live?

FRANCES: I'm pressing my finger on your artery. That stops the bleeding. So, Lt. Stein, where do you come from?

LT STEIN: "Much have I travell'd in the realms of gold."

FRANCES: "And many goodly states and kingdoms seen."

LT STEIN: You like Keats, too.

FRANCES: He helps me dodge bullets ... so I can carry on here ... even write a little poetry.

LT STEIN: *[Pause as the lieutenant groans.]* Nurse. I know I'm done for. How much longer do I have?

FRANCES: As long as my finger's here, Lt. Stein!

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LT STEIN: I know it's bad. I could feel the bullets stitching me down the back.

FRANCES: But you can still speak poetry.

LT STEIN: Why are you here? Somebody like you?

FRANCES: Reading too much Walt Whitman, I guess.

LT STEIN: Sure. Old Walt nursed the wounded in the Civil War. "Every hour of the light and dark is a miracle/every cubic inch of space is a miracle." *[A pause as he stares at her.]*

LT STEIN: Do you really write poetry?

FRANCES: Yes.

LT STEIN: Recite one. Please.

FRANCES: *[Recites:]* If Whitman wrapped your head in white flags of bandages he'd soothe that black space in the corner of your soul's face and you could reach peace that Americans sings of each to each.

LT STEIN: *[After a pause.]* I...like that. You should send it to *Stars and Stripes* so the troops can read it.

FRANCES: Not too many poetry loving GI's like us, Lt. Stein.

LT STEIN: *[Groans in pain.]* Nurse ... you can be honest with me ... Whitman to Whitman. I know the score.

FRANCES: "Nothing is good or bad but thinking makes it so." Now we're with Shakespeare, Lieutenant Stein. *[The sound of trucks leaving. we see fatigued Frances holding on, her finger pressed stubbornly on the artery. Then we hear heavy artillery fire. Then louder artillery fire. Frances slumps over the soldier, her finger finally letting go as her body goes limp.]*

SCENE BREAK

IRENE: *[She is holding **Frances'** helmet.]* After our patients were safely in a new area, we came back for Frances ... and did everything we could for her. But she was hemorrhaging. The doctor and I were unable to stop the

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bleeding in her stomach. *[Pause.]* She died at age 31 on October 21, 1944. From enemy fire. A black soldier played taps. And I sent off one of her poems. *Stars and Stripes* published it. *[Voice of Frances as the lights slowly go down.]*

FRANCES' VOICE: A nurse sees wooden bullets
that splinter as they shoot into the skin,
waterproof bullets where the powder's sealed
so even the moisture of blood can't get in.
In the shock ward she sees it all
soldiers writhing in pain and thirst.
But the wounded never cry
their buddies come first.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lavonne Mueller
Book: The Best American Short Plays 2003-2004
ISBN: 978-1557836960
Publisher: Applause Books
Date (Month/Year): Oct 2006

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier - Duo

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